Boopalarayar were won over, Gonsalves was not. In his evidence, Rodriguez qualified the BI manager Varaprasadam Pillai's statement that he agreed to VOC's overtures only on the condition that the ships were regular —an unexceptional demand. S.K. Marakayar deposed that VOC had given assurance that the company would facilitate their business in all ways.[39] Apart from appealing to patriotic sentiment VOC was only offering better terms.[40] This effort on the part of VOC, when the atmosphere was charged, demonstrates that he was going for the kill: he wanted to ensure that not a single trader from Tuticorin would patronize BI.

By the time the sedition case was foisted against him, VOC claimed with justified, if understated, pride that,

> As the result of the speeches I delivered on the beach and also through my efforts several cattle and cargo shippers who were shipping capital and cargo through the British India Steam Navigation Company's steamers for a long time began to ship by the Swadeshi steamers on or about 25th February.[41]
>
> From the 25th February till 12th March 1908 *not a single merchant shipped his cargo through B.I.S.N. Co's steamers*. One Mr Gonzalez, a nominal cattle shipper, was given some money by the B.I.S.N. Co and he made one or two shipments and that is all the shipments from Tuticorin that the B.I.S.N. Co had during those days.[42]

VOC's claim was confirmed even by a BI employee, Varaprasadam Pillai, in court.[43] Also, by this date, merchants had shifted their business to the newly-started South India Bank's Tuticorin branch—a bank whose directors were all SSNCo's directors.[44] But the company's management was not impressed. On the other hand, they were alarmed by the rising tide of Swadeshism and feared retaliation by the government.

The Coral Mills strike was the last straw, and the ruling cabal could no longer stand up against the government. Already, the local administration was breathing down its neck, with Wynch camping in Tuticorin to stem the Swadeshi tide.

On the afternoon of 7 March, K.R. Guruswami Aiyar, A. Sundara Sastri, the public prosecutor and a director of the company, and a few others came down from Tirunelveli to Tuticorin. With Wynch sending for Guruswami